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Communication Best Practices And Expectations

Texting is a common form of communication that requires a basic level of etiquette. It is best practice to:

1. Keep texts short. More than 160 characters means that a telephone call or email is the better way to deliver your message. Think of texts as preludes or follow-ups to conversation, not the conversation itself.
2. Because of the brevity of most texts, your tone can be misunderstood by the recipient. Texts are best left for general messages such as, "I will be arriving at mediation in less than five minutes" or "Our conference call will start at 2 p.m."
3. Texting is the most informal form of communication. If the message is important, deliver it in person, by telephone, or via email.
4. Spell out all words to eliminate confusion. Never use ALL CAPS, which is the digital equivalent of yelling. Check your spelling; autocorrect will often change words you intended to use into words you did not intend to use.
5. If your conversation requires the exchange of more than 3 texts, it is probably better to communicate face-to-face or by email or telephone.
6. Respect the time of others. Do not send text messages outside of normal business hours (9 a.m.-5 p.m.) unless you have permission or in the case of an extreme emergency.
7. Remember, text messages are also billable events.
8. As an attorney, responding to clients via text can consume entire days. I have to control communication to be able to be an effective attorney.

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